Ruined

By Lynne Nottage

Characters: *Christian (traveling salesman),*
Osembenga (head of government forces),
Kisembe (head of rebel forces)
Soldier (rebel)
Mama (owner of the brothel)
Salima (a prostitute sold to Mama by Christian)

MAMA: **(pg 8-10)** *(Impatiently.)* What did you bring me?

CHRISTIAN: Go on. Take a peek in the truck.

MAMA: How many?

CHRISTIAN: Three.

MAMA: I don't know. They look used. Worn.

CHRISTIAN: C'mon, Mama. Take another look. You've said it yourself business is good. *(Mama considers, then finally.)*

MAMA: Okay, one. That one in front. *(Points)* How much? How much for the one?

CHRISTIAN: It's been a good week, and I'll tell you what, I'll give you two for the price of one. Why not?

MAMA: Are you deaf? No. Tst! I don't need two more mouths to feed. *(then reconsiders)* But, I'll only pay for one. *(Yelling.)* Josephine! Josephine! Take them out back. Get them washed and some proper clothing. . . *(to Christian)* Did you at least tell them this time?

CHRISTIAN: Yes. They know and they came willingly. Salima is from a tiny village. She was captured by rebel soldiers; the poor thing spent nearly five months in the bush as their concubine. She says her husband is a farmer, and from what I understand, her village won't have her back. Because . . .

MAMA: And the other?

CHRISTIAN: Sophie. Sophie is . . . is . . . Look, militia did ungodly things to the child, took her with . . . a bayonet and then left her for dead. And she was – ruined.

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INTRODUCTION

The Congo – a country devastated by civil war, where an estimated 48 women are raped every hour . . . Where the death toll has reached over 5.4 million – the deadliest conflict since World War II. Today, it is still one of the most dangerous places on Earth. And in the heart of the conflict, we find Mama Nadi's brothel – a safe haven for a few women who have escaped the villages. But how can a war be resolved when all factions are prone to unbridled violence? How can a country and its people be anything other than . . . Ruined by Lynn Nottage

(Pg 29-31) *Commander Osembenga, a pompous peacock of a man in dark sunglasses, a gold chain, and a jogging suit, struts into the bar. He wears a pistol in a harness. Osembenga stands erect waiting to be acknowledged.)*

MAMA: *(Flirtatiously.)* Good evening.

OSEMBENGA: It is now. *(He gives the place a once-over.)*

MAMA: Can I get you something?

OSEMBENGA: Bring me a cold Primus. A pack of cigarettes, fresh. *(Mama produces a chair for Osembenga, then she fishes into the cooler for a beer.)*

MAMA: *Monsieur,* I must ask you to leave your bullets at the bar, otherwise you don't come in.

OSEMBENGA: And if I choose not to.

MAMA: Then you don't get served. I don't want any mischief in here. Is that clear? *(Osembenda is charmed by her tenacity. He laughs with the robust authority of a man in charge.)*

OSEMBENGA: Do you know who I am?

MAMA: I'm afraid you must edify me. And then forgive me, if it makes absolutely no difference. Once you step through my door, then you're in my house. And I make the rules here. *(Osembenga laughs again.)*

OSEMBENGA: All right, Mama. Forgive me. *(Osembenga makes a show of removing the bullets from his gun and placing them on the table.)* And who said I don't respect the rule of law?

MAMA: *Monsieur,* I don't recall seeing you here before. What brings you to *mon* hotel?

OSEMBENGA: Jerome Kisembe, the rebel leader. *(Osembenga studies her face to gauge the response.)* You know him, of course.

MAMA: I know of him. We all know of him. His name is spoken here at least several times a day. We've felt the sting of his reputation.

OSEMBENGA: So, you do know him.

MAMA: No, as I said I know of him. His men control the road east and the forest to the north of here.

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OSEMBENGA: Is that so?

MAMA: Yes, but you must know that. *(Osembenga speaks to Mama, but he is clearly addressing everyone in the audience.)*

OSEMBENGA: This Jerome Kisembe is a dangerous man. You hide him and his band of renegades in your villages. Give them food, and say you're protecting your liberator. What liberator? What will he give the people? That is what I want to know! What has he given you, Mama? Hm? A new roof? Food? Peace?

MAMA: Me, I don't need a man to give me anything.

OSEMBENGA: Make a joke, but Kisembe has one goal and that is to make himself rich on your back, Mama**.** *(Osembenga grows loud and more forthright as he speaks.)* He will burn your crops, steal your women, and make slaves of your men all in the name of peace and reconciliation. Don't believe him. He, and men like him, these careless militias wage a diabolical campaign. They leave stains everywhere they go. And remember the land he claims as his own, it is a national reserve, it is the people's land, our land. And yet he will tell you the government has taken everything, though we're actually paving the way for democracy.

MAMA: I know that, but the government needs to let him know that. But you, I'm only seeing you for the first time. Kisembe I hear his name every day.

OSEMBENGA: Then hear my name, Commander Prestige de Bembe Osembenga. *(A moment. Mama absorbs the news, she seems genuinely humbled.)* You will hear my name quite a bit from now on.

MAMA: Commander Osembenga, forgive me for not knowing your name. *Karibu.* [Welcome.] It's a pleasure to have such an important man in our company.

OSEMBENGA: You are a practical woman, I know that you have the sense to keep your doors closed to rebel dogs. Am I right?

MAMA: *(an aside to audience)* **(Pg 51)** My doors are open to everybody. And that way trouble doesn't settle here. *(to Osembenga)* Of course. *(calling for one of her girls)* **(Pg 16)** Salima! Salima, come!

SALIMA: *(Salima, disgusted, bristles at the sound of her name. She reluctantly approaches and does a little shimmy for Osembenga)* So, "gangsta," you wanna dance with me? . . . . *(Osembenga responds and then freezes in place as Salima steps out of the scene he will exit*

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as Salima begins her story) . . . **(Pg 22)** *(to audience)* Sometimes their hands are so full of rage that it hurts to be touched. *(long pause as Salima remembers the past)* **(Pg 45-46)** Do you know what I was doing on that morning? I was working in our garden picking the last of the sweet tomatoes. I put Beatrice down in the shade of a tree, because my back was giving me some trouble. The sun was about to crest, but I had to put in another hour before it got too hot.

CHRISTIAN: **(pg 28)** *(Christian enters and also addresses the audience in a separate but interlocking monologue)* It's scaring me. I was just by Yaka-Yaka. When I was there six months ago, it was a forest filled with noisy birds, now it looks like God spooned out heaping mouthfuls of earth! It's been ugly, but never like this. Not here.

SALIMA: **(Pg 45-46)** It was such a clear and open sky. This splendid bird, a peacock, had come into the garden to taunt me, and was showing off its feathers. I stooped down and called to the bird. "Wssht, Wssht." And I felt a shadow cut across my back, and when I stood four men were there over me, smiling, wicked schoolboy smiles.

CHRISTIAN: **(Pg 50)** *(with urgency)* Listen, listen to me. I saw a boy, take a machete to a man, sever his neck, a clean blow and lift the head in the air like a trophy.

SALIMA: **(Pg 45-46)** "Yes?" I said. And the tall soldier slammed the butt of his gun into my cheek. Just like that. It was so quick, I didn't even know I'd fallen to the ground. Where did they come from? How could I not have heard them?

CHRISTIAN: **(Pg 50)** Men were hollering. "We strong warriors, we taste victory. We will kill!"

SALIMA: **(Pg 45-46)** One of the soldiers held me down with his foot. He was so heavy, thick like an ox and his boot was cracked and weathered like it had been left out in the rain for weeks. His foot was so heavy and it was all I could see, as the others . . . "took" me. My baby was crying. She never cried, but she was crying, screaming. "Shhh," I said. "Shhh." And right then *(Salima closes her eyes.)* A soldier stomped on her head with his boot. And she was quiet. *(A moment. Salima is overcome with grief.)*

CHRISTIAN: **(Pg 50-51)** Oh shit, my hand, my hand is still shaking. This . . . this man Osembenga is evil. He plays at democracy. But we have to pretend that all this ugliness means nothing. We wash the blood off with buckets of frigid water, and whitewash our walls.

SALIMA: **(Pg 45-46)** I fought them! I did! But they still took me from my home. They took me through the bush, raiding thieves. F**** demons!

SOLDIER: "She is for everyone, soup to be had before dinner,"

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SALIMA: They tied me to a tree by my foot, and the men came whenever they wanted soup. I make fires, I cook food, I listen to their stupid songs, I carry bullets, I clean wounds, I wash blood from their clothing, and, and, and … I lay there as they tore me to pieces, until I was raw … five months. Five months. Chained like a goat. These men fighting … fighting for our liberation. Still I close my eyes and I see such terrible things. Things, I cannot stand to have in my head. How can men be this way? *(A moment.)* How did I get in the middle of their fight? What did I do? I must have done something. *(Salima fades offstage as Kisembe, leader of the rebel forces enters, zipping his pants)*

MAMA: **(Pg 51-52)** Kisembe, I hope my girls gave you good company.

KISEMBE: Very. It is good to be back, Mama. Where's everyone?

MAMA: You tell me. It's been this way for a week. I haven't seen but a handful of miners.

KISEMBE: It is Commander Osembenga. He is giving us some trouble. His men set fire to several of our mining villages. They took machetes to anything that moves. This is their justice. Believe me, when we find Osembenga and his collaborators, he will be shown the same mercy he showed our people.

SALIMA: *(Mama fades back into Salima to finish her story)* **(Pg 45)** Five months in the bush, passed between the soldiers like a wash rag. Used. **(Pg 47)** I walked into the family compound expecting wide open arms. An embrace. Five months, suffering. I suffered every single second of it. And he, the man I loved since I was fourteen chased me away with a green switch. **(Pg 45)** He called me a filthy dog, and said I tempted them. Why else would it happen? I was made poison by their fingers, that is what he said. He had no choice but to turn away from me, because I dishonored him. **(Pg 47)** He was too proud to bear my shame . . . but not proud enough to protect me from it. *(Salima fades)*

KISEMBE: **(Pg 52-53)** They say we are the renegades. They bring soldiers from Uganda, drive us from our land and make us refugees . . . and then turn us into criminals when we protest or try to protect ourselves. I wish [I] could stay all day, but duty calls. *(Exits)*

MAMA: **(Pg 57)** You men kill me. You come in here, take your pleasure, and then wanna judge the way I run my "business." The front door swings both ways. I don't force anyone's hand. My girls, ask them . . . ask them, they'd rather be here, any day, than back out there in their villages where they are taken without regard. They're safer with me than in their own homes.

OSEMBENGA: *(Enters)* **(Pg 62)** This soldier said he saw Jerome Kisembe here.

MAMA: This soldier is liar.

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OSEMBENGA: Where is Kisesmbe? *(Frightening. Menacing)* Tell me where I can find Kisembe.

MAMA: I don't know where he is . . . *(to audience with ferocity)* **(Pg 57)** I didn't come to here as Mama Nadi, I found her the same way miners find their wealth in the muck. I stumbled off of that road without two twigs to start a fire. I turned a basket of sweets and soggy biscuits into a business. I don't give a damn what any of you think. This is my place, Mama Nadi's! **(Pg 59)** Let all the mother-hating soldiers fight it out. 'Cuz in the end do you think that will change anything here?

A resource with background information regarding the Congolese conflict and examples of the dialect for this selection can be viewed here and is highly recommended

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NXvZdTvQGiI&index=1&list=PLF6F07EC529297AF2

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lynne Nottage
ISBN: 978-0822223900
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service
Date (Month/Year): 2010

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
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